



FOR HAPPIER, HEALTHIER INDOOR CATS

Indoor Cat Enrichment & Play Guide

Turn your home into a cat's paradise: play that satisfies the hunting instinct, 30 easy DIY ideas, food puzzles, clicker training and a 4-week enrichment calendar.



WHAT'S INSIDE

- Why enrichment matters
- Play styles & the prey sequence
- 30 DIY enrichment ideas
- Vertical space & environment
- Food puzzles & foraging
- Clicker training basics
- Multi-cat & stress signs
- 4-week calendar + play log

30

DIY enrichment ideas

4 weeks

Ready-made enrichment calendar

10–15 min

Play sessions that satisfy



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HOW TO USE THIS PDF

Read it on screen or print the whole thing. Worksheet pages are designed to be printed again and again, so feel free to print extra copies of any tracker you use often. Tip: print at “Actual size” on US Letter paper.

Why Enrichment Matters

Indoor cats live safer, longer lives — but they still have the instincts of a hunter.

Keeping your cat indoors protects them from traffic, predators and many diseases. The trade-off is that the indoor world can be predictable and a little dull. **Environmental enrichment** means giving your cat chances to do what cats are built to do: hunt, climb, scratch, explore, hide, sniff and rest in safe, comfortable spots.

What enrichment can help with

Healthy weight

Active play and food puzzles burn energy and slow down fast eaters.

Less stress

Predictable routines, hiding spots and choice help cats feel in control.

Fewer “problem” behaviors

Night-time zoomies, pouncing on ankles and scratching furniture often ease when needs are met.

Confidence

Shy cats gain courage through gentle play and training successes.

A sharper mind

New challenges keep cats of every age mentally engaged, including seniors.

A stronger bond

Daily play and training build trust between you and your cat.

The five pillars of a healthy cat environment

Feline welfare experts, including the American Association of Feline Practitioners (AAFP) and International Society of Feline Medicine (ISFM), describe five key needs:

- 1 **A safe place** — somewhere to hide and feel secure, like a covered bed, box or high perch.
- 2 **Multiple, separated key resources** — food, water, litter boxes, scratching posts, play areas and resting spots, spread out and not lined up in one place.
- 3 **Opportunities for play and predatory behavior** — hunting-style play and foraging.
- 4 **Positive, consistent, predictable human interaction** — letting your cat choose when and how to interact.
- 5 **Respect for your cat’s sense of smell** — avoiding strong scents and letting cats spread their own scent by rubbing and scratching.

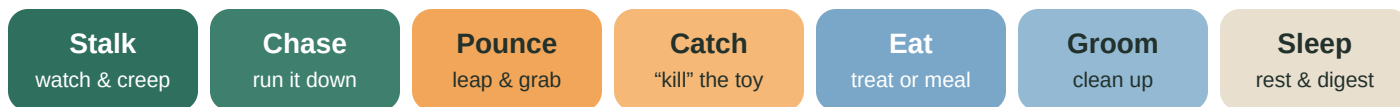
Important: This guide is general education, not veterinary advice; consult your veterinarian about your own pet’s health, diet, medications, and any symptoms that concern you. Sudden changes in behavior, appetite, litter box habits or activity can signal a medical problem, so check with your vet before assuming it’s boredom.

Play Styles & the Prey Sequence

Great play isn't about wearing your cat out — it's about letting them complete a satisfying "hunt."

The prey sequence

In nature, cats make many small hunts a day. Each follows a pattern. When play mimics this full sequence, cats tend to feel more satisfied and settle more easily afterward.



How to play like prey

- 1 **Use a wand toy** so your hands are never the target.
- 2 **Move like real prey:** prey moves *away from* or *across* your cat's path, never straight at them. Mix darting runs with pauses, hide the toy behind furniture, and let it "rustle" under a blanket.
- 3 **Let them win:** allow frequent catches. A cat that never catches anything can become frustrated.
- 4 **Wind down:** slow the movements for the last few minutes, like tired prey.
- 5 **Finish with a final catch and food:** end on a catch, then offer a meal or a few treats. This completes the "hunt, catch, eat" cycle and often leads to grooming and a nap.
- 6 **Put wand toys away** after play — strings and feathers can be dangerous if chewed or swallowed.

What kind of hunter is your cat?

Bird hunters

Love feathers flying through the air, leaping high. Try feather wands and toys that flutter above.

Mouse / ground hunters

Love things that scurry along the floor and hide. Try furry mice on wands, toys under rugs or paper.

Bug hunters

Love tiny, erratic, twitchy movements. Try small wiggly wand attachments and crinkle balls.

Ambush hunters

Love hiding and pouncing. Use tunnels, boxes and paper bags as hideouts during play.

HOW MUCH PLAY?

Most adult cats do well with **two or more play sessions a day of about 10–15 minutes**, often at dawn and dusk when cats are naturally active. Kittens and young cats may need more; seniors may prefer shorter, gentler sessions.

ABOUT LASER POINTERS

Lasers can be fun, but the "prey" can never be caught. If you use one, finish by landing the dot on a real toy or treat your cat can catch. Never shine it in eyes.

30 DIY Enrichment Ideas

Most of these cost little or nothing. Try a new one each day — the calendar later in this guide will help.

- 1 Box castle**
Tape several cardboard boxes together and cut doorways and windows.
- 2 Paper bag cave**
Cut off handles first. Crinkly, hideable and free.
- 3 Toilet-roll treat puzzle**
Fold the ends of a cardboard tube with a few kibbles inside.
- 4 Egg-carton forager**
Place kibble in the cups; close lightly for a challenge.
- 5 Muffin-tin game**
Hide treats under ping-pong balls in a muffin tin.
- 6 Treat hunt**
Hide small portions of dry food around the room before you leave.
- 7 Snuffle blanket**
Scatter kibble in the folds of a fleece blanket.
- 8 Ping-pong in the tub**
Drop a ball into a dry bathtub for a noisy bouncing chase.
- 9 Cat TV**
Put a bird feeder outside a window (safely out of pounce range).
- 10 Window perch**
Add a sturdy perch or cleared sill with a view.
- 11 Bubble chase**
Blow pet-safe bubbles for cats who like to leap.
- 12 Sniff box**
Put a sock or toy with a new scent (a friend's dog, garden herbs) in a box.
- 13 Catnip or silvertop refresh**
Rub a little on a scratcher or toy once or twice a week.
- 14 Cat grass garden**
Grow wheat, oat or barley grass for safe nibbling.
- 15 Tunnel of fun**
Connect boxes or a fabric tunnel along a wall.
- 16 Blanket mouse**
Wiggle a wand toy under a blanket or rug.
- 17 Kicker pillow**
Stuff an old sock with fabric scraps and a pinch of catnip; sew closed.
- 18 Ice-cube treat**
Freeze a little water with a few kibbles for hot days (supervised).
- 19 Toy rotation box**
Keep toys in a box and swap 3–4 out each week so they feel new.
- 20 Cardboard scratcher**
Stack and glue cardboard strips on edge in a shallow box.
- 21 Shelf staircase**
Install secure wall shelves to create a climbing route.
- 22 Hide-and-seek**
Call your cat from another room and reward with a treat when found.
- 23 Clicker trick session**
Teach a nose-touch or “high five” (see page on training).
- 24 Crinkle paper ball**
Loosely scrunched paper makes a great batting toy.
- 25 Laundry basket fort**
Flip a basket upside down with a toy inside to paw at.
- 26 Scent trail**
Drag a treat along the floor to a hidden reward.
- 27 Outdoor experience**
Harness training or a secure catio for safe fresh air.
- 28 Nature videos**
Try bird or fish videos on a tablet; watch that your cat stays relaxed.
- 29 Grooming spa**
A gentle brushing session with treats for cats who enjoy it.
- 30 New cardboard day**
Every delivery box is a new adventure — remove staples and tape first.

SAFETY CHECK FOR EVERY DIY TOY

Remove staples, tape, plastic, strings, ribbons and handles. Avoid small pieces that could be swallowed. Supervise new toys, and put away anything that's getting chewed apart. Some cats don't react to catnip at all (it's inherited), and young kittens often don't respond — silvertop or valerian are alternatives some cats enjoy.

Vertical Space & Environment

Cats live in three dimensions. Adding height instantly adds territory — no extra square footage needed.

Why height matters

High places let cats survey their territory, escape from dogs or kids, and avoid conflict with other cats. A confident cat often chooses the highest perch; a shy cat may feel safer up high or tucked away.

Ideas to go vertical

- ☐ Tall, stable cat tree near a window
- ☐ Wall-mounted shelves forming a “cat highway”
- ☐ Cleared top of a bookcase with a soft pad
- ☐ Window perch or hammock
- ☐ Stair-step shelves up to a favorite spot
- ☐ Multiple routes up and down (so no one gets trapped)

Hideaways

Every cat needs at least one place to be unseen. Provide covered beds, boxes on their side, cat caves or a blanket-draped chair. Never pull a cat out of a hiding place — it’s their safe zone.

Scratching

Scratching keeps claws healthy, stretches muscles and leaves scent marks. Offer both:

- **Vertical** posts tall and sturdy enough for a full stretch (they shouldn’t wobble)
- **Horizontal** cardboard or sisal scratchers

Place scratchers near sleeping areas and in social spots like the living room — cats like to scratch where they’ll be noticed.

Resource setup checklist

Resource	Good practice	Done
Litter boxes	One per cat plus one, in quiet spots on different sides of the home; large and uncovered suits many cats; scoop daily	☐
Food & water	Water away from food and litter; wide, shallow bowls; consider a fountain	☐
Resting spots	Soft beds in warm, sunny and elevated places	☐
Sensory	Window views, cat grass, occasional new scents and textures; avoid strong fragrances and essential oil diffusers	☐
Safety	Secure window screens, no toxic plants (especially lilies), cords secured	☐

BUDGET TIP

Sturdy shelves with carpet or cork squares, a cleared windowsill and a few cardboard boxes can create an exciting vertical playground for very little money.

Food Puzzles & Foraging

Wild cats spend a large part of their day hunting for many small meals. Food puzzles bring back a little of that work.

Food puzzles (also called foraging toys) make your cat move, think and use their paws to get food. Researchers and feline veterinarians have reported benefits such as weight loss, slower eating and less attention-seeking behavior in some cats.

Types of food puzzles

Stationary puzzles

Your cat reaches into holes, tubes or compartments to fish out food. Great for beginners and for cats who like to use their paws.

Mobile puzzles

Balls or shapes that release kibble as they roll. Great for active cats who like to chase.

Lick mats

Textured mats spread with wet food. Calming and good for slowing down wet-food eaters.

Scatter feeding

Toss kibble across a room, cat tree or snuffle mat so your cat “hunts” each piece.

Getting started

- 1 **Start very easy.** Put a few high-value treats in the puzzle so food falls out with almost no effort.
- 2 **Stay close** the first few times and reward interest.
- 3 **Increase difficulty slowly** as your cat succeeds — frustration makes cats give up.
- 4 **Measure food:** use part of your cat’s daily food ration in puzzles rather than adding extra.
- 5 **Offer several puzzles** around the home and rotate them to keep things interesting.

WATCH THE FOOD INTAKE

Make sure your cat is actually eating enough when you switch to puzzles, especially at first. Cats should not go without food — a cat that stops eating for more than a day or so needs to see a veterinarian.

KEEP IT CLEAN

Wash puzzles regularly, especially those used with wet food. Replace any that crack or break.

My cat’s food puzzle notes

Puzzle / method	Difficulty (1–5)	Liked it?	Notes

Training Cats: Clicker Basics

Cats are very trainable with the right motivation — and training is great mental exercise.

Clicker training uses a distinct sound to mark the exact moment your cat does something right, followed by a reward. It's positive, force-free and fun. You can also use a short word like "Yes!" or a tongue click.

Before you start

- **Find the right reward:** tiny pieces of a favorite treat, a lick of wet food or tuna-style paste on a spoon.
- **Train before a meal** when your cat is a little hungry.
- **Keep it short:** 2–5 minutes, a few times a day. Stop while your cat is still interested.
- **Quiet space:** start where there are no other pets or distractions.

Step 1: Charge the clicker

- 1 Click, then immediately give a treat. Your cat doesn't need to do anything yet.
- 2 Repeat 10–15 times per session for a few sessions.
- 3 When your cat looks for a treat after hearing the click, you're ready.

First tricks

Target (nose touch)

Hold a chopstick or target stick a few inches from your cat's nose. When they sniff or touch it, click and treat. Gradually move it so your cat follows. Targeting helps move your cat without lifting them — onto a scale, into a carrier or off the counter.

Sit

Wait until your cat sits on their own, then click and treat ("capturing"). Or hold a treat slightly above and behind their head. Once your cat sits reliably, add the word "sit" just before.

Come when called

Say your cat's name or shake a treat bag, click when they arrive, and reward. Start from a short distance and build up. Very handy in emergencies!

High five

Hold a treat in a closed fist just above floor level. When your cat lifts a paw to touch it, click and treat. Gradually raise your hand and switch to an open palm.

Go to mat

Click and treat each time your cat steps onto a mat or bed. Great for keeping cats off counters during meal prep.

Happy carrier

Leave the carrier out with a soft blanket. Toss treats nearby, then inside. Click and treat for stepping in. Makes vet trips much easier.

NEVER PUNISH

Punishment (spraying water, yelling, swatting) can damage trust and increase fear-related problems. Instead, reward the behavior you want and make unwanted choices less rewarding or less available.

Multi-Cat Tips & Signs of Boredom or Stress

Cats are individuals. Understanding their signals helps you spot problems early.

Keeping peace between cats

- **Duplicate resources** in separate locations: feeding stations, water, litter boxes, beds and scratchers.
- **Offer multiple routes** in and out of rooms and up and down cat trees so no cat can block another.
- **Play one-on-one:** some cats won't play if another cat is watching. Use two wand toys or separate sessions.
- **Feed separately** if one cat eats another's food or if cats have different diets.
- **Introduce new cats slowly** over days to weeks: separate room, scent swapping, feeding on opposite sides of a door, then short supervised visits.
- **Watch for subtle bullying:** blocking doorways, staring, guarding the litter box.

Play or fight?

Play	Fighting
Quiet or few sounds	Hissing, growling, yowling
Cats take turns chasing	One cat always chases or blocks
Relaxed ears and body, soft pauses	Flattened ears, puffed fur, arched back
Both come back for more	One cat hides or avoids the other

STEPPING IN

Interrupt real fights with a noise or by placing a pillow between cats — never your hands. Separate them to calm down and consult your vet or a behavior professional if it continues.

Signs of boredom or stress

Possible boredom

- Night-time zoomies and waking you up
- Ambushing ankles or rough play with hands
- Knocking things off shelves for attention
- Overeating or begging constantly
- Destructive scratching or chewing

Possible stress

- Hiding more than usual
- Over-grooming or bald patches
- Urinating or defecating outside the litter box
- Changes in appetite or sleep
- New aggression, hissing or excessive vocalizing

Important: This guide is general education, not veterinary advice; consult your veterinarian about your own pet's health, diet, medications, and any symptoms that concern you. Many of these signs can also be caused by pain or illness. Book a vet visit for any sudden change. **Emergency:** a cat (especially a male cat) straining in the litter box with little or no urine may have a urinary blockage, which is life-threatening — get veterinary care immediately.

4-Week Enrichment Calendar

Each day has one featured idea, plus your usual two play sessions. Check a box for each session completed.

Cat's name _____ Start date _____

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Week 1	Wand toy hunt + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Box castle + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Treat hunt + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Paper bag cave + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Clicker: charge + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Cat TV window + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Toy rotation + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐
Week 2	Blanket mouse + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Toilet-roll puzzle + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Clicker: target + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Ping-pong in tub + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Sniff box + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Snuffle blanket + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Brush + chill + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐
Week 3	Feather wand + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Muffin-tin game + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Clicker: sit + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Tunnel of fun + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Catnip refresh + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Hide-and-seek + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Toy rotation + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐
Week 4	Bug-hunt play + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Egg-carton forager + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Clicker: high five + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Laundry basket fort + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Cat grass + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Scent trail + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐	Favorite repeat! + 2 play sessions ☐ ☐ ☐

TIPS

Adjust freely — swap days, repeat favorites, and skip anything your cat doesn't enjoy. Keep the most exciting activities for when your cat is naturally active (often early morning and evening).

Top 3 favorites this month

Printable Play Log

Tracking play helps you discover your cat’s favorite games, best times, and how their energy changes.

Cat’s name _____

Week of _____

Date	Time	Minutes	Toy / activity	Prey type (bird, mouse, bug)	Energy (1–5)	Caught it? Treat after?	Notes

Best time of day

Favorite toy

Try next week



Thank you for playing!

Thank you for choosing Mavilo Pet Co. A few minutes of thoughtful play and a little creativity can transform your indoor cat's world. Watch what lights your cat up, follow their lead, and enjoy discovering the playful, curious hunter inside your companion.

Play daily

Two short hunting-style sessions go a long way.

Rotate often

Novelty keeps toys and puzzles exciting.

Respect choice

Let your cat decide when to engage and when to rest.

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